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The Line

1912 was a year of upheaval and change throughout Asia. World War I had not yet broken out, but other forces were stirring throughout the continent. On the first day of the year, Asia's first republic was proclaimed, the Republic of China. After years of simmering discontent and local uprisings in various parts of China, a military revolt at Wuchang in Hubei province had broken out on 10 October 1911. 'Double Ten Day', as it became known among republican nationalists, served as the catalyst for a wider uprising against the ruling but increasingly inept Qing Dynasty.

The leader of the anti-Qing movement, Dr Sun Yat-sen, was not in the country at the time. He had been living in exile in for several years, organizing resistance among overseas Chinese in Hawaii, southeast Asia, and Japan. Accompanied by an American adventurer called Homer Lea, Dr Sun returned home on 21 December 1911 to oversee some of the most dramatic events in modern Chinese history. Eight days later, a gathering of delegates representing anti-Qing groups from all over the country elected Dr Sun the 'provisional president' of the republic, a role he assumed on New Year's Day. On 12 February 1912, the last emperor, six-year-old Pu Yi, was forced to abdicate.

But the end of more than two thousand years of imperial rule did not, as the revolutionaries and reformers had envisaged, usher in an era of modernity and prosperity in this vast and desperately poor country. Power struggles and intrigues led to chaos and instability. Dr Sun resigned after less than seven weeks in office and was succeeded by Yuan Shikai, a military officer and hardly a democratic reformer. In December 1915, Yuan even proclaimed himself emperor, a title he held for 83 days. Amidst several rebellions in his realm, Yuan had to relinquish his imperial title and